

THE STORY BANK

James George · Companion to Interview Brief v3. Seventeen real experiences, mapped to the nine pilot competencies, each one mouldable to a dozen different questions. Plus a fact-check of the brief: one genuine error, three things to soften.

THE RULE, INHERITED FROM YOUR BRIEF AND NON-NEGOTIABLE. *Highlighted brackets* are details only you hold — fill them from memory, never from invention. Every story here is drilled with follow-ups precisely because fabricated detail collapses at the second question. And the competency being assessed above all others is safety awareness, which is fundamentally the habit of telling the truth when it costs you something.

ONE THING TO SETTLE BEFORE YOU PREPARE ANYTHING. Your April interview pack (the Jet2-era document) describes a different set of experiences from this brief — a weather diversion with a pan-pan call, an oil-level check before a solo, a thermal collapse on a cross-country, a fleet-records spreadsheet, a misidentified checkpoint. None of those appear anywhere in Brief v3, which is otherwise exhaustive. **Before you take any of them into this interview, confirm each one is a real memory of yours.** If any were drafted as illustrations rather than recalled, leave them out entirely — you do not need them. The seventeen below are enough, and they are yours.

Part 0 · Fact-check of Brief v3

I verified the material claims against British Airways' Speedbird FAQ (14 April 2026), BA's media centre, Skyborne's own pages, Aeros, the UK CAA and EASA/ICAO competency documentation. **The brief is accurate almost throughout** — the numbers, the course structure, the training standards, the terms, the leadership and the CRM theory all stand. Four corrections follow.

1 · A genuine error — Aeros

The brief says Aeros "appears to support the self-sponsored pathway." That is wrong, and the correction is useful to you rather than merely pedantic.

The accurate position: Aeros Flight Training is a selected partner delivering **elements of training within the fully funded 2026 Speedbird Pilot Academy itself**, via a **modular route** (their Fast-Track and Flexi-Track approaches) for candidates who already hold or are working toward modular ratings. The 2026 Academy is exclusively fully funded. BA separately runs a *Speedbird Self-Sponsored Pathway* — a different scheme — which is almost certainly where the confusion came from.

Why this matters to you specifically. You hold a PPL. That makes you exactly the profile the modular route exists for — so **"why the integrated route with us rather than modular?"** is now a live question, and it was not in your brief. Have this ready:

"I've done the modular thing already, in miniature — I funded a PPL in pieces around a job and a business, and I know what it costs you in continuity. You lose time to rescheduling and you re-learn things you'd have retained if the phases had run together. Integrated is seventy weeks of momentum with a cohort of eight to twelve going through it at the same pace. Having done it the fragmented way, I'd take the continuous one deliberately."

That answer is only available to you *because* you self-funded. Nobody straight out of school can say it.

2 · Three figures to soften

BRIEF SAYS	WHAT THE SOURCES ACTUALLY SUPPORT	SAY INSTEAD
"25,000+ applicants in previous years"	BA and its coverage say "tens of thousands"; the 2026 round was reported as expecting "over 20,000"	"Over twenty thousand" — or just "tens of thousands." Don't quote 25,000 as fact.
"Fewer than 50 graduates to date"	BA's own April 2026 wording is "nearly 50 pilots have graduated and integrated into flight deck operations"	"Nearly fifty so far." Same number, and it sounds like momentum rather than scarcity.
Phases listed as 28 + 26 + 9.5 + 0.5 + 3	That sums to 67, not the stated 70 weeks — the balance is transitions and phase gaps	Quote the phases or the 70-week total, never both in a way that invites the subtraction. "Roughly 70 weeks, in five phases" is safe.

3 · Everything else checks out

Verified: Skyborne founded 2016 by Lee Woodward with Tom Misner, Woodward CEO / Misner chairman / Ian Cooper COO, both Woodward and Cooper ex-airline with senior roles at other academies · Gloucestershire (Staverton) HQ, Bournemouth second base, Vero Beach acquisition completed May 2021 · phases 28 weeks theory, 26 weeks single-engine/CPL at Vero Beach, ~10 weeks ME/IR · ground school standard of first-series pass at 85% average, max 3 resits, first-series CPL and ME/IR, max 1 recourse, and BA's stated right to withdraw the conditional offer · starting salary £37,081 plus allowances · six-year short-haul fleet freeze with bidding between BA and Euroflyer · £18m and up to 160 places for 2026, fourth year running, ~£100,000 per cadet · Sean Doyle Chairman & CEO, Simon Cheadle Director of Flight Operations fronting the academy · 13 UK CAA ATPL exams · the nine EASA/ICAO pilot competencies · PACE, TEM, just culture and normalisation of deviance all correctly described.

4 · One thing missing that you were asked last time

Your ATPL scholarship panel probed **exam validity** and your brief never states the numbers. Know them cold, because you are applying for ATPL theory funding separately and it is the obvious follow-up: **all 13 exams must be completed within 18 months of your first attempt**, with a **maximum of 4 attempts per subject and no more than 6 sittings**; once complete, the **theory passes are valid for 36 months** for CPL/IR issue, and thereafter tied to your IR validity for ATPL issue. On Speedbird this is academic — the course runs the theory in 28 weeks — but being able to say it in one sentence demonstrates you understand the pathway you'd be leaving behind.

Part 1 · How moulding actually works

You will be asked perhaps twelve competency questions in forty-five minutes and you have seventeen experiences. The skill is not having more stories; it is **re-entering the same story through a different door**.

The mechanism, in one line: the facts never change — the **opening sentence** and the **closing line** change, and you re-weight *which two or three Action steps* you dwell on.

ELEMENT	CHANGES?	WHY
Situation & facts	Never	Altering facts to fit a question is how candidates get caught. If the story doesn't fit, use a different story.
Opening sentence	Always	It names the competency back to them in the first five seconds, so the assessor knows which box to write in. This is the single highest-leverage sentence in any answer.
Which Actions you emphasise	Yes	Same six things you did; you spend your airtime on the two that evidence <i>this</i> competency.
Closing line	Always	The transferable lesson is what gets written down. It must be the lesson for the competency asked, not the one you rehearsed most.

The two hard limits on moulding. (1) **One event, one use per interview.** If you've told the reception incident as leadership, it is spent — teamwork must come from elsewhere. Hence the reserves in Part 4. (2) **Don't reuse a closing construction.** The winch cable and the deep end both close on asymmetric consequences — "the cost of being early versus the cost of being late." Use that reasoning once. Twice and it reads as a formula rather than as how you think.

Part 2 · The nine pilot competencies — your actual syllabus

BA's invitation names six plain-English areas. Underneath them sits the **EASA/ICAO nine-competency framework** that every airline now trains and assesses against. An ab-initio interview asks about lifeguarding and roofs because those experiences *predict* these nine. Knowing them by name is a differentiator almost no cadet candidate has — but hold it in reserve; deploy it only if asked directly about CRM or competency frameworks.

COMPETENCY	WHAT IT MEANS ON A FLIGHT DECK	WHERE YOUR EVIDENCE IS
KNO — Application of Knowledge	Knowing the aircraft and the rules, and being able to apply them, not just recite them	Nine PPL exams first time, one a month · explaining the diving rule from the injury mechanism
PRO — Procedures & Compliance	Following SOPs, including when nobody would notice if you didn't	Winch cable · alarm before entering the water · roof tile disclosure
COM — Communication	Clear, verified, two-way — including handovers and briefings	Briefing the receptionist for the 999 call · paramedic handover · difficult customer
FPA — Flight Path, Automation	Managing and monitoring automation	Thin, and that is fine at ab-initio. If pushed: G1000 exposure, and the point that monitoring is the skill that decays
FPM — Flight Path, Manual	Hands-and-feet flying, energy management	Gliding — 100 hours solo across five types, energy management with no engine, when to come home
LTW — Leadership & Teamwork	Leading, following, delegating, speaking up, supporting a decision once made	Reception (both cuts) · winch driving as club service · cadets · running a business
PSD — Problem Solving & Decision Making	Deciding well on incomplete information, then reviewing	Deep end · winch cable · gliding field-vs-home decisions
SAW — Situation Awareness	Noticing, projecting forward, knowing what you don't know	Deep end · the aircraft low over the threshold · frayed cable
WLM — Workload Management	Prioritising, shedding, sequencing, staying ahead of the aircraft	Gloucester (rushing = the classic WLM failure) · reception task-split · three jobs at once

The sentence that ties it together, if they ask why a lifeguard makes a pilot: *"The nine competencies airlines assess aren't really about aeroplanes — they're about noticing early, deciding on incomplete information, communicating so the other person actually has it, and protecting the procedure when it's inconvenient. I've been doing all four for money since I was sixteen, just at pool level rather than flight level."*

Part 3 · The bank

Each block: the spine (unchanged facts), the competency coverage, the **moulds** (opening and closing lines by question type), and what to fill. Brackets follow your brief's convention.

01 · THE FRAYED WINCH CABLE — your strongest asset

PROPSAWLTWCOM

Spine. First solo in a glider. Briefed, cleared, sitting in the aircraft. You noticed the winch cable was frayed and tangled. You could have flown — nobody had stopped it, everyone was ready. You stopped it, told **[who]**, and asked to be swapped to the other line so the day kept running and you still flew. Airborne **[when]**, delay of **[X]** minutes.

MOULDS

IF THEY ASK...	OPEN WITH	CLOSE WITH
Spoke up when something wasn't right	"My first solo — years of work to get to that seat, everyone ready, and I'm the one who stopped it."	"A cable failure on a winch launch happens low and fast. Twenty minutes of waiting and the alternative aren't comparable things."
Followed a rule that was inconvenient	"The check nobody watches you do is the one that matters."	"Checks only ever earn their keep on the day they find something. That was the day."
Difficult decision / one that cost you	"The most expensive decision I've made in aviation cost me my own first solo launch."	"It was the cheapest thing I've ever bought, in hindsight."
Put others ahead of yourself	"I didn't want the launch cancelled — I wanted the risk gone. Those aren't the same request."	"Stopping the day would have been easy and useless. Finding the other line kept everyone flying."
Noticed something others hadn't (SAW)	"Several people had been past that cable that morning. So had I."	"You don't get credit for noticing — you get credit for what you do in the ten seconds after."
Integrity / honesty	"Nobody would have known if I'd just flown it, including me, probably."	"The version of me that flies it is the version that later can't be trusted with anything smaller."
Went against the group	"Everyone was ready. The queue was behind me. That's the pressure, and it's not spoken."	"Being the one who says 'wait' is uncomfortable for about a minute and useful for the rest of your career."

Fill: was checking it your job or did you just see it? · did anyone push back, even mildly — "it'll be fine", "we've launched on worse"? **Holding a position after a first no roughly doubles this story's value** · did the club change anything afterwards (cable retired, inspected, replaced)?

Drill: "What if someone senior had told you it was fine?" · "How did you know it was unserviceable?" · "Where's the line between assertive and difficult?" · "What if there'd been no second line?"

Do not narrate this in PACE terms. Tell it as what happened; let them notice.

02 · RECEPTION — THE CALL (leadership cut)

LTW COM WLM PSD KNO

Spine. Lifeguarding at [venue]. A woman in her [age] fell in reception and broke her hip. Second on scene with a new receptionist who was panicking, a pool still full of swimmers, and nobody formally in charge. You recognised it was two jobs, not one, and you couldn't do both: you took the casualty as the trained first aider and gave the receptionist the 999 call — **telling her exactly what to say** [the four things]. Decided **not** to move her. Talked to her continuously. The other lifeguard never left poolside. Structured handover to the paramedics.

MOULDS

IF THEY ASK...	OPEN WITH	CLOSE WITH
Took the lead when nobody else would	"Nobody was in charge, and the gap lasted about three seconds before it needed filling."	"Leading wasn't giving orders — it was noticing it was two jobs and that I could only hold one."
Stayed calm when others weren't	"The receptionist was panicking, and the fastest way to stop that wasn't to reassure her."	"Someone with a clear job to do stops panicking. Giving her the call was the calming, not the words."
Managing several priorities at once (WLM)	"Two emergencies competing: a casualty in reception and a pool that hadn't stopped being dangerous."	"Everyone's instinct is to converge on the incident. What made it work was someone staying on the thing that hadn't gone wrong yet."
Explained something complicated to someone who didn't understand	"I didn't tell her to call an ambulance. I told her what to say, in order."	"A panicking person gives a bad handover — so I removed the thinking from the task and left her only the doing."
Communicated clearly under pressure	"The handover to the paramedics was the part I'd thought about while I was waiting."	"What I'd done, and what I'd deliberately <i>not</i> done — the second half is the half people forget to hand over."
Delegation / trusting others	"I gave away the job I'd have found easier and kept the one I was trained for."	"Delegating the thing you'd rather do is usually the tell that you've allocated correctly."

Fill: the four things you told her to say · why you kept talking to the casualty · the outcome for her.

Drill: "What if she'd frozen anyway?" · "Why not make the call yourself?" · "Were you the right person to take charge?" · "How did you know not to move her?"

Never say aloud: that this is task allocation under load, or that the handover is structurally a briefing. Let them see it.

03 · RECEPTION — THE TEAM (teamwork cut — same event, cannot be used in the same interview as 02)

LTW COM SAW

Spine, re-weighted. Three people, three jobs, one incident pulling all of them the wrong way. The other lifeguard **held the poolside** — the discipline of the whole thing, because the water was still the bigger risk. The receptionist took communications. You took the casualty. Lead with the split, not with yourself, and **name what she did well** [what the receptionist got right once she had a job].

Closing line for this cut: "Nobody allocated those roles — we fell into the right ones. And that only worked because each of us knew the others' jobs well enough not to have to discuss it."

Crediting a named colleague for something specific reads far better than crediting "the team". **Teamwork answers usually describe effort; this one describes role clarity under load**, which is rare at your stage.

04 · THE DEEP END

SAW PSD PRO COM

Spine. Swim school. A boy newly moved up a stage, in the deep end for the first time; you were on the chair covering that end. He started bobbing and gasping — not shouting, not waving. The cue that made it distress rather than play was *[vertical in the water, head tipping back, mouth at the waterline, no forward progress]*. You didn't wait to be sure: *[X]* seconds from noticing to out of the chair. **Alarm before entering the water, not after** — because that brings help and gets the rest of the pool covered while you're committed. Out within seconds. Then the second half of the job: calming him, and calming the parents who'd watched.

MOULDS

IF THEY ASK...	OPEN WITH	CLOSE WITH
Quick decision, incomplete information	"I was never certain he was drowning. That's the whole point of the story."	"The cost of going early was looking slightly silly. The cost of going late isn't the same size of problem — so they don't get weighted the same."
Noticed something before anyone else	"Drowning doesn't look like it does on television — which is exactly why you're trained to recognise one specific picture."	"Recognition isn't instinct. It's a picture someone taught me, and I'd looked at it a thousand times before it was real."
Followed procedure under pressure	"The instinct is to get in the water. The procedure is to hit the alarm first, and the order matters."	"Committing yourself without telling anyone leaves the rest of the pool uncovered. The alarm is for them, not for me."
Dealing with people who are upset	"Getting him out took seconds. The parents took a lot longer, and that was the actual job."	<i>[what you said to them]</i>

Fill: your specific recognition cue · seconds elapsed · what you said to the parents · outcome and whether anything changed afterwards.
Drill: "How do you know he wasn't fine?" · "What if you'd been wrong and a parent complained?" · "Have you got that judgement wrong the other way?"
Careful: shares its closing logic with the winch cable. Use the asymmetric-consequence reasoning in **one** of them, not both.

05 · THE ROOF TILE

PRO COM PSD LTW

Spine. Your own exterior cleaning business. Roof clean on *[type]*; you damaged a tile. Invisible from the ground — the customer would never have known, and by the time water ingress showed up as a leak *[when]*, nothing would have connected it to you. You noticed *[when]*. You told him before leaving site — not just that you'd cracked it, but what would happen if it were left and where it would show up inside. Offered to replace it at your own cost and to check the rest of the roof while up there. He thanked you, tipped you, left a good review.

MOULDS

IF THEY ASK...	OPEN WITH	CLOSE WITH
A significant mistake	"I broke something a customer would never have found."	"The cheap moment to own a mistake is immediately. The cost of a hidden one grows with time."
Integrity / honesty when it cost you	"The whole story is about the ten minutes where nobody would have known."	"The outcome was better than concealing it would have been — but that isn't why I did it, and I'd have done it if he'd been furious."
Just culture / self-reporting (direct)	"I can give you a definition, but I'd rather give you the time I did it."	"A system only hears about problems if the person who caused one is better off telling you. I've been on the reporting end of that and it worked."
A difficult conversation	"I had to go and find him and start with the worst sentence."	"Leading with the consequence rather than the excuse is what made it a two-minute conversation instead of an argument."
What you changed permanently	"The lesson wasn't 'be careful on roofs'."	<i>[the system change — photographing roofs before starting, flagging fragile surfaces at quote stage, different access or footing]</i>

Fill (the scored element): what you subsequently changed — your ATPL feedback is explicit that this is what's marked, so it is **not optional**. Also: **be honest about whether you briefly considered saying nothing**. If you did, say so — admitting the pull to conceal is what makes this credible.

Drill: "What if he'd been furious and refused to pay?" · "Have you ever *not* owned up to something?" · "What would you do if you saw a fellow cadet make an error and say nothing?"

06 · GLOUCESTER — HELD BACK

WLM KNO PSD COM

Spine. PPL navigation training into Gloucester — one of the busiest GA airports in the country, radar service, instrument traffic. Your instructor told you he wasn't sending you solo: you were rushing. *[Did it sting? Say so if it did.]* What he'd seen was *[specifics]*. You didn't argue — you asked what specifically he wanted to see different, because "slow down" isn't actionable. Then changed *[what]*. *[N]* flights later he sent you solo into Gloucester. His line: "**slow is smooth, and smooth is fast.**"

MOULDS

IF THEY ASK...	OPEN WITH	CLOSE WITH
Difficult feedback	"I was told I wasn't going solo, on the day I expected to."	"I'd been treating speed as competence. It's the opposite — and that's the single biggest thing that was holding me back."
A failure / setback	"Being held back is a small failure with your name on it and no one else to blame."	"What changed wasn't my attitude, it was four specific habits. Attitude alone doesn't survive a busy zone."
Your weakness (this is the honest one)	"When I feel behind, my instinct is to speed up — which is exactly the wrong input."	"It was identified by an instructor, I actively manage it now, and I'd rather tell you that than invent something safer."
Managing workload / being behind	"Getting behind the aircraft on the way into a busy zone is a workload problem, not a flying problem."	"Now when I'm behind I slow the inputs and do one thing properly, rather than trying to catch up on all of them."
How you take instruction / trainability	"The useful question wasn't 'why not?' — it was 'what specifically do you want to see different?'"	"Vague feedback can't be acted on, so the responsibility is partly mine to turn it into something specific."
Hypothetical: failing a progress check	"I've had a version of this already, and it's the reason I'd handle it the same way."	"Raise it immediately, diagnose why rather than just repeating the work, change the method, and use a resit knowingly rather than accidentally."

This one story answers **five separate questions** — feedback, failure, weakness, workload, and the progress-check hypothetical. It is the most efficient item in the bank. Don't waste it on a question another story covers.

07 · THREE JOBS AT ONCE — BA NAMED THIS AREA IN WRITING

WLM PSD LTW

Status: still a situation, not a story. Running the business, lifeguarding around forty hours a week, working through the PPL with the flying paid from what you earned — so hours worked set the rate you could fly at. That is excellent raw material and it currently contains **no decision**, which is the entire competency. "I was busy and I worked hard" scores nothing.

Answer these five in writing this week and the story builds itself:

1. Did you ever have to choose between a shift and a lesson? Which won, and **how did you decide**?

2. What did you **stop** doing? (Business marketing, quoting, certain job types, social life, something else?)

3. Did you turn work down to protect flying, or fly less to protect the business? Which way did it go, and why that way?

4. Did you hand anything over to anyone, or change how you scheduled?

5. **Did you ever decide not to fly because you were too tired after a shift?**

If the answer to (5) is yes, lead with it. That is an airmanship decision, not a diary decision, and it is worth more than the other four combined — it is you applying a fatigue-management judgement to yourself years before anyone required it of you.

Closing line once filled: "The useful move wasn't working harder — it was being honest about capacity early enough that I still had a choice about what to shed."

Drill: "How do you know you shed the right thing?" · "What if you'd realised two weeks later?" · "Thirteen exams in twenty-eight weeks with no job around it — how does this apply?" · "What happens to the business during the course?"

08 · THE DIFFICULT CUSTOMER — needs your event

COM LTW PSD

BA's FAQ states outright that customer service experience is valuable in cadets, so this is likely. **Don't reuse the roof tile** — that's your mistake story, and one event serving two questions weakens both.

The four moves that score, in order: (1) **you went to them** rather than waiting to be chased — timing matters more than wording; (2) **you apologised without explaining** — your reasons are true and they are your problem, not theirs; (3) **you asked what would actually help** instead of assuming, and it turned out to be something other than what you'd assumed; (4) **you kept them informed** even with nothing new to say.

Recognition prompts — which of these actually happened? Someone who disputed the price after the work was done · a finish that was genuinely as good as that surface gets, where the job was managing an expectation rather than redoing work · someone who kept adding work beyond the quote · someone who wanted you to reach something you couldn't safely access and wasn't happy being told no · a complaint about mess, overspray, water or access, theirs or a neighbour's · a late payment chased without burning the relationship · someone dismissive because of your age · from lifeguarding, a parent who argued about a rule or a swimmer you removed from the water.

Note the fourth prompt. "A customer who wanted you to reach something you couldn't safely access, and wasn't happy being told no" is not really a customer-service story — **it's a second safety story**, and a commercially costly one. If that happened, it may be worth more than the difficult-customer answer it's sitting in. Flag it to yourself separately.

The reserves — build at least two of these before the call

Your brief identifies these as gaps. They are the difference between a bank that survives twelve questions and one that runs dry at eight.

RESERVE	COVERS	WHAT TO LOOK FOR IN THE MEMORY
Army cadets	LTW, away-from-home, followership	How long, camps and exercises, any rank held, a time you were led by someone you disagreed with, a time you were responsible for someone younger. This is your honest answer to "you'll be away from home for months" — an honest cadets answer beats a padded expedition story, which always fails at the second follow-up.
HGV workshop	PRO, SAW — a <i>second</i> safety story	A defect someone wanted to defer. If that happened, it is close to a perfect story: commercial pressure against a safety judgement, in a regulated industry, with a vehicle that goes on public roads. It would free up the winch cable for a different question.
Kitchen	COM, LTW — conflict	A disagreement handled without it becoming personal; working with someone you found difficult; sustained pressure with no ability to stop the flow of work.
Club service winch driving, cable retrieving	LTW, followership, volunteering	BA names volunteering as an acceptable source and their FAQ calls it a strong addition. Frame it once, explicitly, as unpaid service that keeps an operation running — not as something you just do. A busy launch point is also your reserve teamwork story if the reception incident is spent.
The Waterside group exercise	Self-awareness	You did it days ago. What would you do differently? This is the best-evidenced self-awareness answer available to you and nobody else in the process can offer one this fresh. Have two sentences ready.
Building the business	Pride, resilience, commercial maturity	For "something you're proud of", this beats a flying achievement — motivation, resilience and commercial maturity in one, and it's the engine that funded everything else.
Nine exams, one a month	KNO, study method	Your method, then do the arithmetic out loud before they do : one a month is a nine-month rate; ground school is 13 in 28 weeks, roughly double, on deeper subjects, to 85% first series. Name what you'd change — active testing and question banks from week one rather than reading, marking yourself hard, tracking question types you get wrong, a study group, and raising a weak subject in week two rather than week six.

Part 4 · The routing table

Listen for the competency, then route. Getting this mapping right matters more than the wording of any answer — your ATPL feedback names "not answering the question asked" as a distinct failure mode.

QUESTION	PRIMARY	IF ALREADY SPENT
Spoke up when something wasn't right	Winch cable	HGV defect · roof tile
A significant mistake you made	Roof tile	Gloucester (as a habit, not an event)
Difficult feedback / a failure	Gloucester	Waterside group exercise reflection
Quick decision, incomplete information	The deep end	Winch cable · a gliding decision to come home
Took the lead when nobody else would	Reception — the call	Cadets · running the business
Teamwork on something difficult	Reception — the team	Busy launch point · cadets · kitchen
Several competing priorities	Three jobs at once	Reception (two jobs, one person)
An unhappy customer	Difficult customer	A parent who argued about a rule
Stayed calm when others weren't	Reception	The deep end
Noticed something before anyone else	The deep end	Aircraft low over the threshold · winch cable
A rule you followed when it was inconvenient	Winch cable	Alarm-before-entry · a lifeguarding procedure you held to
Explained something complicated	Briefing the receptionist	Explaining a quote or a process to a customer
Disagreement in a team	Kitchen / workshop / club (build it)	Winch cable, if you were pushed back on
Someone you found difficult to work with	Kitchen / workshop (build it)	—
Adapting when a plan changed	Weather scrubbing a job day	A gliding day changing · a shift swap absorbed
Put someone else's needs first	Covering a shift	Winch cable, read as the operation over your own solo
Something you're proud of	Building the business that funded the flying	Solo at fourteen
Your weakness	Rushing when behind (Gloucester)	— never invent a safer one
Away from home / independence	Cadets + business + 40-hour weeks	— be honest about what you haven't done
Volunteering	Winch driving & cable retrieving	Club task days

Part 5 · The three scenarios — reasoning, not stories

"How do you cope when..." and "what would you do if..." want your **reasoning aloud**, not a STAR answer. Your brief covers the first two fully; hold these shapes.

SCENARIO	THE SHAPE OF A STRONG ANSWER
Captain briefs an approach you believe is wrong, and dismisses your first concern	Principle first — being junior doesn't remove my responsibility for the safety of the flight. Then check yourself: what's my evidence, and could I be the one who's wrong? Escalate via PACE — I've probed and been dismissed, so I alert with the evidence rather than repeat myself louder. Bring in a third source — ask ATC to confirm the approach in use, which turns it from my word against his into a fact neither of us owns. Name your limit plainly. Debrief on the ground, not as a complaint.

Captain who regularly makes small SOP deviations	Name the real risk — normalisation of deviance : no single deviation is dangerous, but repeated non-compliance erodes the margins the SOPs exist to protect, and nobody notices the day they ran out. Gather facts first — is it a deviation, a company variation, or my misunderstanding? Conversation before report , at a quiet moment. Escalate proportionately via the confidential reporting process if it continues. Then say the uncomfortable part: seniority doesn't make something safe, and saying nothing because he outranks me makes me part of it.
A cadet drinking the night before an early flight	Speak to them directly, then report. Say it without hedging — soften the manner if you like, never the outcome.

The trap in all three: composure when they push back. Your ATPL feedback defines assertiveness as expressing an opinion with conviction, explaining your reasoning, **and remaining composed when challenged or questioned further**. Being fluent for two minutes and then wobbling under "and what if you'd been wrong?" is the failure mode. The correct response to that follow-up is not to retreat — it's *"Then I'd have been wrong, and I'd rather be wrong out loud at four thousand feet than right and silent."*

Part 6 · Rehearsal — the week

WHEN	WHAT
Tonight	Answer the five questions in Slot 07 in writing. Fill every bracket in stories 01–06. Confirm the April-pack stories are real memories or discard them.
Day 2	Identify the difficult customer event. Mine cadets and the HGV workshop for the two reserves. Two sentences on the Waterside group exercise.
Day 3	Say every story aloud, timed. Anything over two minutes: cut the Situation, never the Action. Anything under forty seconds is underweight.
Day 4	Moulds only. Take one story and answer four different questions with it, changing only the opening and closing lines. This is the session that makes the bank flexible.
Day 5	Full 45-minute mock on Teams, dressed as on the day, using the mock sheet in your brief. Random order, follow-ups after every answer, timed. A comfortable mock is a wasted mock.
Day 6	Find your current aviation story yourself — something you've actually read and have a view on. Set pieces aloud three times each. Test the tech.
Night before	Read the sticky note of eight titles and nothing else. Stop preparing.

THE LAST THING TO READ BEFORE YOU JOIN THE CALL. You have flown since you were thirteen, gone solo at fourteen, accumulated a hundred hours across five types, completed a PPL in minimum hours, passed nine exams first time, and paid for all of it out of a business you built and a forty-hour week. You stopped your own first solo because a cable wasn't right. Nearly fifty people have graduated from this academy; the reason it exists is a stated intention to remove cost as the barrier — **you are the case that policy was written for**. You are not hoping to be found suitable. Slow down about fifteen percent, say "I", and let them see it.

Sources for the fact-check: BA Speedbird Pilot Academy FAQs (14 April 2026) · BA Media Centre, fully-funded programme opens for fourth year (14 April 2026) · Skyborne Speedbird and FAQ pages, UK facilities and fleet · Aeros Flight Training and FLYER/AFM coverage of the Aeros partnership · Businesswire, Skyborne completion of Vero Beach acquisition (May 2021) · Punchline Gloucester and Insider Media on Skyborne's founding · UK CAA ATPL(A) and PPL(A) licensing pages · EASA/ICAO competency framework documentation (IATA CBTA guidance, EASA Flight Examiner Manual). Checked 14 August 2026.